UIC Department of Chemical Engineering Town Hall Agenda

Date: October 1, 2024
Time: 12 pm
Location: 124 EIB or Virtual Meeting Link
Facilitator: [Insert Independent Facilitator Name]

Objective:
The focus of this town hall is to foster collaboration, exchange ideas, and address key concerns regarding the direction and development of the Department of Chemical Engineering. We aim to engage all participants—students, faculty, and staff—in a shared discussion and ensure mutual agreement on future actions.

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1. Welcome and Overview of Meeting Format (10 minutes)

- **Facilitator:** [Facilitator's Name]
- Explanation of meeting structure and ground rules for participation
- Objectives of this town hall and emphasis on open, collaborative dialogue
- Introduction of key faculty members:
    - **Department Head**: Dr. Vikas Berry
    - **Director of Undergraduate Studies**: Dr. Alan Zdunek
    - **Director of Graduate Studies**: Dr. Brian Chaplin
- Overview of today's single topic focus: **"Shaping the Future of the Chemical Engineering Department: Programs, Initiatives, and Improvements"**

2. Brief Departmental Update (15 minutes)

- Each faculty member will provide a concise update on the department, relevant to their role:
    - **Dr. Vikas Berry**: Department vision, strategy, and overall goals
    - **Dr. Alan Zdunek**: Undergraduate program updates
    - **Dr. Brian Chaplin**: Graduate program updates

- Purpose: Provide context for the town hall discussion and align participants on current progress

3. Collaborative Discussion: Shaping the Future of the Department (40 minutes)

- **Facilitator:** Engages participants in a structured conversation to ensure balanced and inclusive participation
- **Topics for Discussion:**
    - **Academics/Curriculum:** Identifying gaps, strengths, and opportunities for improvement
    - **New Initiatives/Events:** Ideas for enhancing student and faculty engagement
    - **Suggestions for Improvement:** Actionable recommendations for department growth
- **Format:** Each group (students, faculty, staff) will share their perspectives, followed by open dialogue where ideas are exchanged and refined. Participants will actively listen and respond constructively.

4. Prioritizing Action Items (15 minutes)

- Facilitator will guide the group to prioritize key ideas and actionable steps based on the discussion.
- Agreement on:
    - Immediate improvements to implement
    - Long-term goals and initiatives
    - Who is responsible for each action item
- **Establish a Working Group:** Representatives from all parties (students, faculty, staff) to meet separately and finalize action plans.

5. Closing Remarks and Next Steps (5 minutes)

- Summary of the key points and next steps
- Schedule for the next town hall meeting
- Contact information for ongoing feedback
- Commitment to ongoing collaboration and follow-up

Action Items:

1. **Working Group Formation:** Representatives from students, faculty, and staff to solidify action steps.
2. **Follow-up Meeting:** Working group to reconvene and confirm next steps.
3. **Next Town Hall:** Scheduled to review progress and continue the collaborative discussion.

Note:
The facilitator will ensure that the discussion remains collaborative, productive, and focused on mutual understanding and constructive problem-solving.

- Town hall meetings should be an assembly agreed upon by all parties.
- All parties should have active roles in designing the exchange of ideas.
- Each meeting should be limited to one topic.
- An independent facilitator is best to guide the flow and serve as a responsible timekeeper, ensuring that all perspectives are granted ample time and that participants are talking with one another and not at one another.
- Every meeting should end with action items, and representatives for all sides should reconvene in a smaller group to agree on priorities and next steps—including scheduling the next town hall meeting.

As a communications professional, I believe the goal of town hall meetings falls somewhere on the axis between awareness and engagement. They should not be an inflection point in issues management, but rather a pre-emptive communications device for multiway flow of information and progress toward mutual understanding.